of Abul Fazal. Similarly, Badauni's outstanding work, *Tarikh-i-Badauni* (Badauni's History), was published in 1595. This work spans three volumes. The volume on Akbar's reign is a frank and critical account of Akbar's administration, particularly of his religious policy.

Travellers and Travelogues

Marco Polo, a Venetian traveller, visited when the Pandya kingdom was becoming the leading Tamil power in the 13th century. Marco Polo was twice in Kayal, which was a port city (presently in Thoothukudi district of Tamilnadu). It was full of ships from Arabia and China. Marco Polo tells us that he himself came by a ship from China. According to Marco Polo, thousands of horses were imported into southern India by sea from Arabia and Persia.

Al-Beruni (11th century) accompanied Mahmud of Ghazni in one of his campaigns, and stayed in India for 10 years. The most accurate account of Mahmud's Somnath expedition is that of Alberuni. As learned man and a scholar, he travelled all over India trying to understand India and her people. He learnt Sanskrit and studied the philosophy of India. In his book *Tahquiq-i-Hind,* Alberuni discussed the Indian conditions, systems of knowledge, social norms and religion.

Ibn Battuta (14th century), an Arab-born Morocco scholar, travelled from Morocco right across North Africa to Egypt and then to Central Asia and India. His travelogue *(Rihla [The Travels])* contains rich details about the people and the countries he visited. According to him, Egypt was rich then, because of the whole of the Indian trade with the West passed through it. Ibn Battuta tells us of caste in India and the practice of *sati.* We learn from him that Indian merchants were carrying on a brisk trade in foreign ports and Indian ships in the seas. He describes the city of Delhi a vast and magnificent city. Those were the days when Sultan Muhammad bin Tughluq transferred his capital from Delhi to Devagiri (Daulatabad) in the south, converting this city into a desert.



Ibn Battuta

In the South, Vijayanagar had many foreign visitors who left behind their detailed accounts of the state. An Italian named Nicolo Conti came in 1420. Abdur-Razzaq came from Heart (the court of Great Khan in Central Asia) in 1443. Domingo Paes, a Portuguese traveller, visited the city in 1522. All of them recorded their observations, which are very useful for us today to know the glory of the Vijayanagar Empire.

Summary

- The period from A.D. (CE) 700 to 1200 and from A.D. (CE) 1200 to 1700 are classified as Early Medieval and Later Medieval periods in Indian history.
- Sources are classified as primary and secondary sources.

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